LIVE • TECHNICAL • 45 MIN

Under the Hood of Copilot Studio's New GitHub Copilot Harness

From answers to real business outcomes

Nicolai Schjørmann
PRINCIPAL PRACTICE LEAD
AUTOMATION & AGENTIC AI



abakion

Who am I?



NICOLAI SCHJØRMANN

- Principal Practice Lead, Automation & Agentic AI @Abakion
- Principal Power Platform Consultant
- 5 years with Abakion
- 12 years with Dynamics CE and Power Platform
- 3 years with Business Central
- 2 years with Agents
- Happy conference speaker and AI / Automation advocate

abakion

AGENDA

From ideas to impact.



1. **Intro**
   Why this matters now
2. **Understanding the Harness**
   What it is, how it differs and when to use it
3. **Under the Hood**
   Runtime, authoring, tools and key capabilities
4. **Live Demo**
   Research → Decide → Create → Act
5. **From Prototype to Production**
   Credits, governance, control and evaluation
6. **Customer Conversation Harness**
   Built for customer resolution
7. **Choose Deliberately**
   A practical framework
8. **Wrap up**
   Key takeaways and next steps

abakion

WHAT IS A

Harness?

The runtime between your agent and the model

MODEL

Reasoning & generation

PROVIDES CAPABILITY

HARNESS



Context • planning • tool calls
interpretation • recovery

EQUIPS AND DIRECTS THE MODEL

AGENT



Instructions • tools
knowledge • skills

YOUR CONFIGURATION

The model provides capability.
The harness equips and directs it.

abakion

TWO DECISIONS

Harness ≠ Model

They solve different questions

HARNESS

How should the work happen?

- Runtime behavior
- Planning and orchestration
- Tool coordination
- Files and execution
- Process shape

AGENT OUTCOME

MODEL

How should the agent reason?

- General vs. deeper reasoning
- Quality and reliability
- Latency
- Consumption
- Availability

The newest model does not compensate for the wrong harness.

abakion

Standard harness

Rule-based, predictable, controlled

- Follows the rules, branches and steps you define
- Best for structured, repeatable tasks
- Predictable, controllable and cost-efficient

GitHub Copilot harness

Reason, plan, and solve across systems

- Takes a goal, plans the steps and adapts as it goes
- Works across tools, files, knowledge, MCP and agents
- Best for complex, multi-step business processes

Contact Conter harness

Answer and resolve for your customers

- Designed for voice and chat customer conversations
- Uses a multi-agent architecture with escalation
- Best for customer service and contact center scenarios



abakion

RUNTIME BEHAVIOR

Standard executes a plan. GitHub Copilot keeps deciding.

STANDARD HARNESS

Plan once, then execute

1. **INTENT** — Understand the request
2. **PLAN** — Create an authored plan
3. **EXECUTE** — Run defined steps
4. **RESPOND** — Return the result

FOLLOWS THE PLAN YOU DEFINE

GITHUB COPILOT HARNESS

Continuously decide from the latest state



Same goal. Different runtime. Very different behavior.

abakion

REALITY CHECK

Different runtime. Different architecture.

WHAT YOU GAIN

- Instructions and skills as primary building blocks
- Agent Sandbox for deterministic work
- Native artifact creation (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, PDF)
- Persistent memory
- Iterative tool orchestration
- Larger and longer-running tasks

GitHub Copilot Harness

A DIFFERENT RUNTIME

WHAT YOU RETHINK

- Deterministic topic paths
- Inline Power Fx logic
- System-variable patterns
- Message and response interception
- Adaptive Card experiences
- Strict grounded-only designs

Don’t migrate it component by component.

Some standard constructs have no direct one-to-one equivalent. The capability may require a different architecture.

abakion

THE AGENT SANDBOX

A workspace for getting the work done



The agent doesn't only answer. It has somewhere to do the work.

abakion

AUTONOMY

Autonomy needs a boundary.

ADAPTIVE AGENT

Understand the goal
Interpret intent and context

Research and gather
Find and compare information

Choose and use tools
Call the right tools and skills

Form a recommendation
Summarise and explain

Create the artifact
Draft, analyse or prepare content

CONTROL BOUNDARY

HAND OFF AT THE RIGHT TIME

DETERMINISTIC WORKFLOW

Validate required inputs
Ensure completeness and correctness

Apply explicit rules
Follow business logic consistently

Route for approval
Human-in-the-loop where needed

Perform system actions
Update records and systems of record

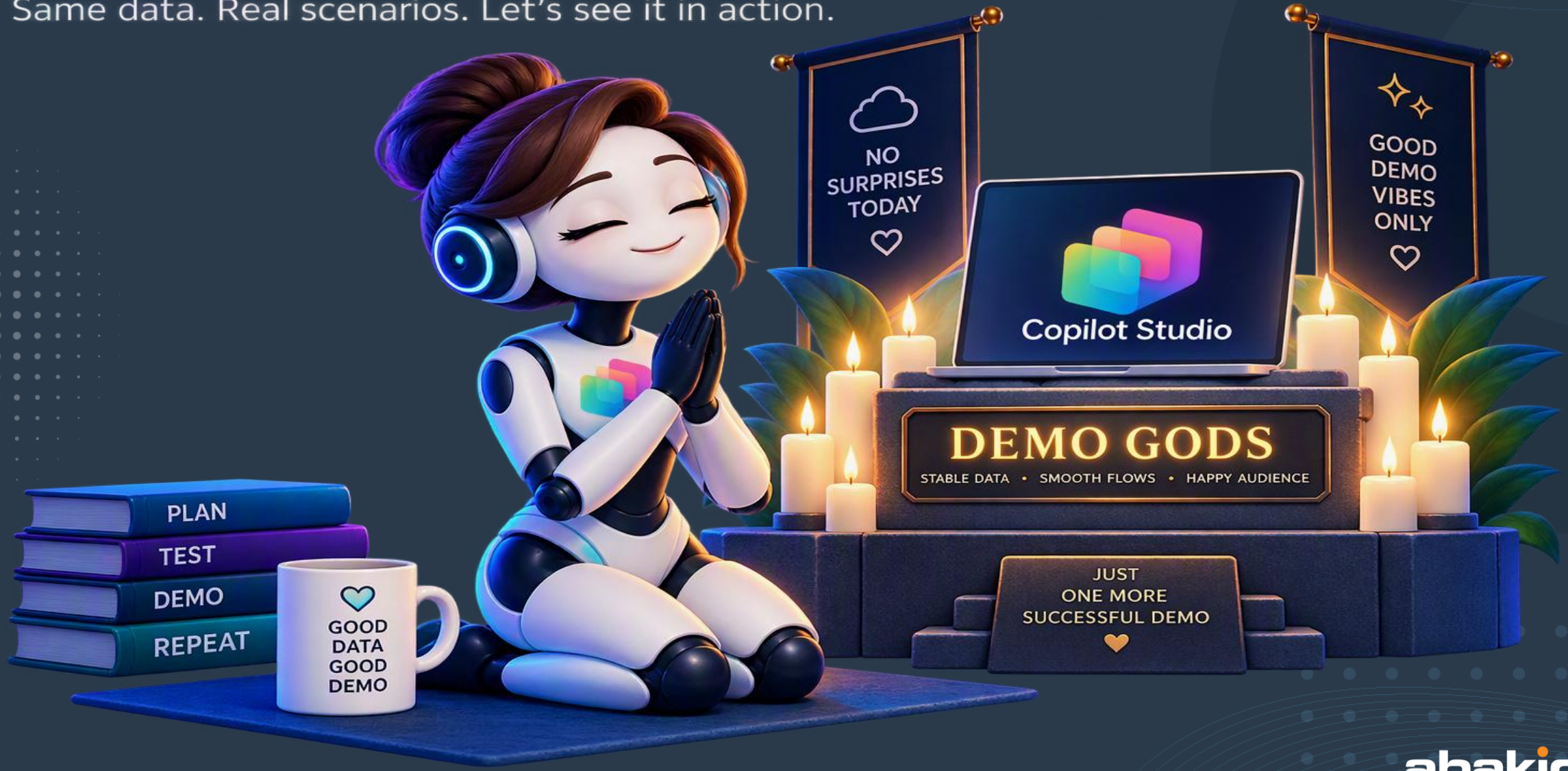
Notify and continue
Close the loop and keep it auditable

Let the agent decide. Let the workflow enforce.

abakion

Demo time

Same data. Real scenarios. Let’s see it in action.



abakion

THE AUTHORING MODEL

The authoring model changes too.



You design the outcome. The harness orchestrates the components.

Natural-language-first doesn't mean architecture-free.

abakion

COMMERCIAL REALITY

The meter starts before production.

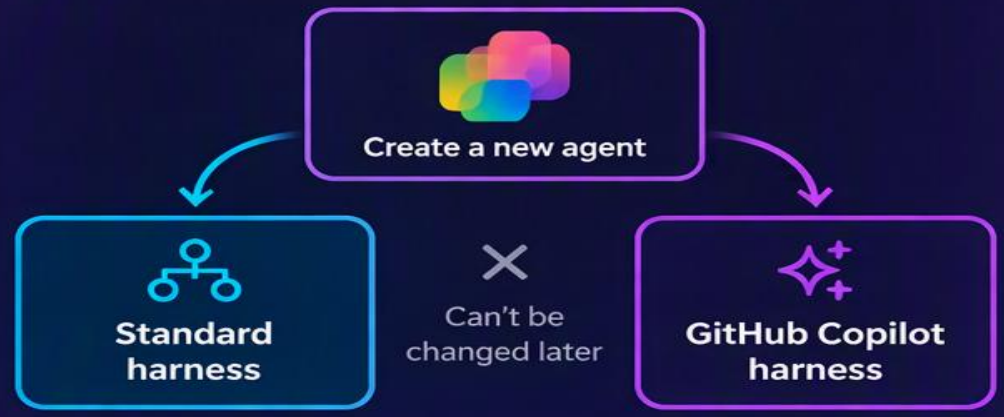
BUILDING ALSO CONSUMES

Using, building, testing and evaluating agents can all consume Copilot Credits.



HARNESS CHOICE IS UP FRONT

You choose the harness when you create the agent, and you can't switch it later.



Prototype the workload before you commit the production architecture.

Understand the value, test the behavior, and estimate the consumption early.

abakion

BEFORE YOU BUILD

Map the work.

KNOW

What information does the agent need?

- Internal data
- External sources
- Files and documents
- Real-time systems

ACT

What is it allowed to change?

- Read or write data
- Create and update files
- Call tools and workflows
- Make system changes

CONTROL

Where must a person approve?

- High-impact decisions
- Thresholds and rules
- Four-eyes principle
- Handoff to a workflow

RECOVER

How do we spot and correct mistakes?

- Missing or wrong data
- Tool failures
- Conflicting information
- Audit and traceability

COST

What dees a completed task cost?

- Copilot Credits used
- End-to-end task cost
- Expected scale
- Business value

Map the work before you decide how autonomous the agent should be.

A clear understanding of the work leads to a better design, lower risk and a more predictable cost.

abakion

RUNTIME CONTROL

Tool vs. Hook

TOOL
AGENT CHOOSES

An available capability the agent can select when relevant.

USE WHEN

Do this when it makes sense for the current task.

EXAMPLE

"Retrieve invoice details when needed."

VS

HOOK
EVENT TRIGGERS

A workflow that runs automatically when a supported event occurs.

USE WHEN

This rule or control must always execute.

EXAMPLE

"Before any write operation, validate policy."

If a control must always run, do not rely on the agent choosing it.

abakion

GOVERNANCE

Govern the plan, not only the prompt.

TECHNICAL BOUNDARY

Control what the agent can access and do.

- Permissions
- Tool exposure
- DLP and data access
- Environment controls

DETERMINISTIC BOUNDARY

Use workflows to enforce required steps.

- Approvals
- Four-eyes principle
- Thresholds and rules
- Irreversible actions

AGENT JUDGEMENT

Help the agent ask for help when needed.

- Missing evidence
- Confilcting information
- Low confidence
- Clarification needed

Safety-critical actions should not depend on the agent choosing to be cautious.

abakion

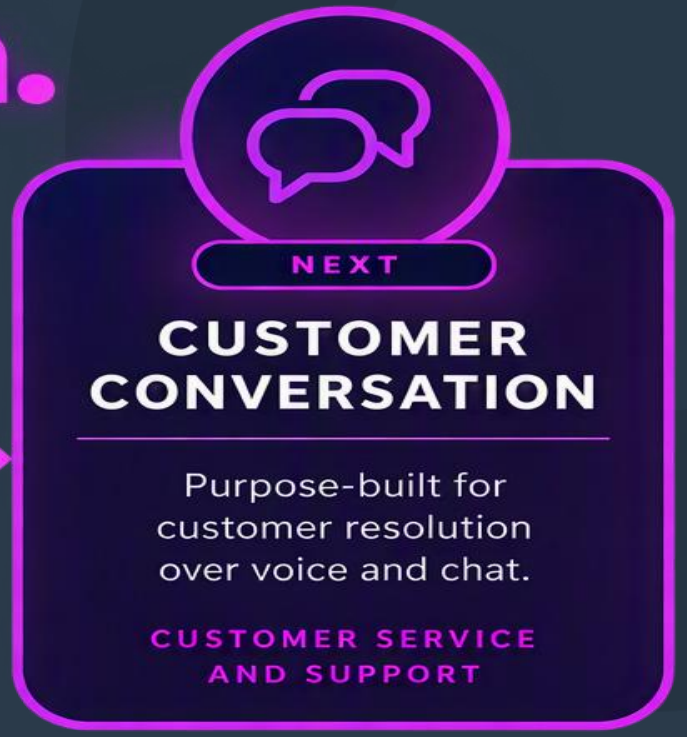
NEXT

From internal tasks to customer resolution.









Same platform. New scenarios. Let's look at the Customer Conversation harness.

abakion

CHOOSE BY BEHAVIOR

A practical harness decision framework.

Question	STANDARD Known path	GITHUB COPILOT Adaptive path	CUSTOMER CONVERSATION Resolution path
Primary interaction	Task / conversation	Outcome-oriented work	Customer voice + chat
Work shape	Short, bounded	Longer, reasoning-heavy	Defined topics + resolution
Control model	Explicit topics / components	Planning + iterative execution	Specialized sub-agents
Human boundary	Designed in topics / flows	Designed around decisions	Native escalation paths
Use when	Predictability dominates	Coordination dominates	Conversation resolution dominates

How much of the path is known before runtime?

abakion

FROM TEST TO TRUST

Measure the system, not the model.

BUILD
Create and configure

→

TEST
Try and iterate

→

EVALUATE
Run test sets and analyse

→

RUN
Live with real users

QUALITY
Does it deliver the right result?

- Task completion
- Grounding and sources
- Correct artifacts
- Relevant and helpful output

RESILIENCE
Does it handle the real world?

- Missing information
- Tool failures
- Denied permissions
- Ambigoous requests

OPERATION
Is it practical to run?

- Response time
- Credits consumed
- Actual tenant availability
- Scalability and limits

CONTROL
Can we trust and govern it?

- Permissions and data access
- Approvals and thresholds
- Audit and traceability
- Consequential actions

The demo proves it **can work.** Evaluation tells you whether you **can depend on it.**

abakion

Wrap up



abakion

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Five things to take home.

1 A HARNESS IS THE RUNTIME

It defines how the agent operates. The model defines how it reasons.

2 CHOOSE FOR THE WORK

Match the harness to the process, not the hype.

3 UNDERSTAND WHAT CHANGES

The GitHub Copilot harness brings new capabilities – and some concepts to rethink.

4 DESIGN FOR CONTROL

Use workflows, approvals and hooks to enforce boundaries. Don't rely on the agent to be cautious.

5 MEASURE THE OUTCOME

Evaluate quality, resilience, cost and real business impact – not just the model or a single answer.

The right harness, model and governance turn possibilities into real business value.

abakion

COMMUNITY SHARING

Under the hood of Copilot Studios new Github Copilot Harness

Get the slides, resources and demo files

Available on **GitHub**

github.com/Schjoermann/presentations/tree/main/2026-10-directions-emea/github-copilot-harness

Slide deck
This presentation

Demo files
Sample data and scripts

Examples
Prompts and use cases

Additional resources
Docs and links



Scan to access

abakion

ANY Questions?

Let’s discuss



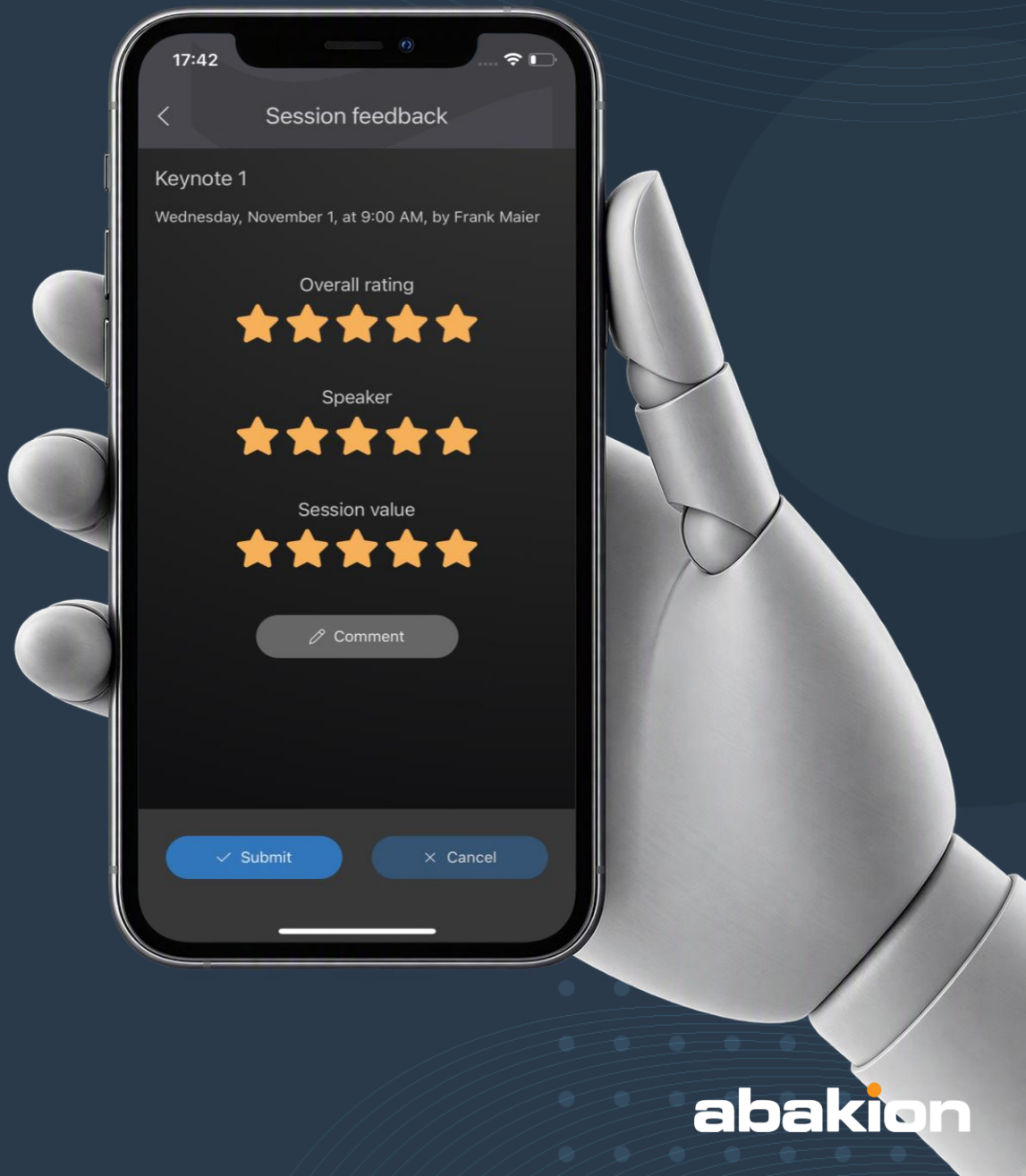
abakion

SESSION FEEDBACK

Your feedback means a lot!

Share your thoughts and
help make future sessions even better.





abakion

Let's connect



Let's keep the conversation going!

- Connect on LinkedIn
- Share ideas
- Explore opportunities
- Build what's next together

abakion